Colonel Wadke had far-reaching consequences in my life. Yet it might also have caused some heartburn among others who wanted to do the same course. I attended the course and topped it despite being the juniormost, and later on was posted as an instructor at the Intelligence School at Poona in 1970.

As young officers we were unaware of the political developments in Nagaland, and confined ourselves to the limited realm of doing our assigned duties in the battalion. We had to carry out a number of long-range patrols in order to get to know the area, just in case the 'ceasefire' with the Naga underground got abrogated. As good regimental officers we shared the hardships with the men and did our best to be their role models. Sometime during 1966 the battalion got orders to be deployed closer to the border with Burma, with company and platoon posts being established all over in the Tuensang district. We became experts in creating infrastructure and rudimentary habitat with bamboo and grass. Most of these new posts were maintained by air. We became adept at using the cotton parachutes to line the interiors of our thatched shacks, so as to protect us from the rain and cold breeze. We learnt that a large group of Naga rebels, including many young recruits, had crossed over to Burma under self-styled General Thinoselie and other leaders of the Naga underground. They were reportedly headed for Yunan province of China to receive training and arms. It was very interesting to know that this group had crossed over from the area where we were now deployed and that they were given traditional feasts with mithuns (semi-domesticated animal of the ox family) being slaughtered, and local drinks like madhu, a variety of rice beer, flowing liberally.

The year 1967–68 was momentous for all of us serving in 8 Mountain Division in Nagaland. Intelligence reports had confirmed that in December 1967, another large gang of Naga underground rebels, led by self-styled generals Mowu Angami and Zuheto Sema and stalwarts like Isaac Swu and T. Muivah, had gone across from the Tuensang area of Nagaland to China, for training and procuring arms. This was a blatant violation of the ceasefire policy. Over 300 young men had been recruited from the Angami, Sema, Ao and